

SUPPORT THE PATIENT TO MAKE A CHANGE

Use the five-A's approach to help the patient make a change in behaviour to help avoid or lessen a health risk:

Ask the patient about the risks

- Identify with the patient the risk/s to his/her health.
- Ask what the patient already knows about these risks and how they will affect the patient's health.

Alert the patient to the facts

- Request permission to share more information on this risk.
- Use a neutral, non-judgemental manner. Avoid prescribing what the patient must do.
- Build on what the patient already knows or wants to know.
- Discuss results of tests or examination that indicate a risk.
- Link the risk to the patient's health problem.

Assess the patient's readiness to change

- Assess the patient's response about the information on his/her risk. 'What do you think/feel about what we have discussed?'
- Use the scale to help patient assess the importance of this issue for him/her. Also rate how confident s/he feels about making a change.

Not at all important/not at all confident	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Very important/very confident
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- Ask the patient why s/he rated importance/confidence at this number. Ask what might help improve this rating.
- Summarise the patient's view. Ask how ready s/he feels to make a change at this time.

Assist the patient with change

If the patient is ready to change:

- Assist the patient to set a realistic change goal.
- Explore the factors that may help the patient to change or may make it difficult.
- Help the patient plan how s/he will fit the change into the routine of the day.
- Encourage patient to use strategies s/he used successfully in the past.

If the patient is not ready to change:

- Respect the patient's decision.
- Invite patient to identify the pros and cons of change.
- Acknowledge patient's concerns about change.
- Explore ways of overcoming the difficulties preventing change.
- Offer more information or support if the patient would like to consider the issue further.

Arrange support and follow up

- Offer referral to counselor and available support services (social worker, health promoter, community care worker, helpline ☎ 178).
- Identify a friend, partner, or relative to support the patient and if possible attend clinic visits.
- Document decision and goals set by the patient.
- Schedule follow-up contact (clinic visit, email, phone) to review readiness and goals.